

Study Information Sheet for Research Participants

Study Title: Understanding Online Romance Scams Targeting Men

Principle Investigator: Anonymized

Email: Anonymized

IRB Protocol Number: Anonymized

Purpose of the Study

You are invited to take part in a research study about online romance scams that target men. This study aims to understand how men become targets of online romance scams where they are asked to share nude photos and later blackmailed. By learning about their experiences, emotions, and responses, we hope to identify ways to prevent such scams and improve support for victims.

What You Will Be Asked to Do

If you agree to take part, you will participate in a one-time, confidential interview (about 45 minutes).

During the interview, you will be asked to describe:

- How the scam started and how you were contacted,
- What interactions took place (e.g., requests for photos, threats, payments), and
- How you responded and sought help afterward.

With your permission, the interview will be audio-recorded to ensure accuracy. You may skip any question you do not wish to answer or stop the interview at any time.

Possible Risks or Discomforts

You may experience mild emotional discomfort when recalling distressing events. You are free to take a break, skip questions, or end the interview at any time. If you feel upset, we can provide information about counseling or support resources. There is also a risk someone outside of the study team could gain access to the research data and it could damage your reputation.

More information on how we plan to protect your information is below.

Benefits

While you may not receive a direct benefit, your participation will help researchers and policymakers better understand online romance scams and how to support victims in the future.

Confidentiality

Your identity and all personal details will remain strictly confidential.

- Your name will not appear in any reports or publications.
- All recordings and electronic data will be stored on encrypted devices only accessible to the research team.
- Only the research team will have access to the data.

Voluntary Participation

Your participation is completely voluntary. You may refuse to take part or withdraw from the study at any time, without penalty or loss of benefits to which you are otherwise entitled. No payment will be provided for participation.

Questions or Concerns

If you have questions about this study, please contact: Anonymized

If you have questions about your rights as a research participant or need to file a complaint, you may contact the Institutional Review Board (IRB) at Anonymized.

By agreeing to participate, you confirm that you have read and understood this information sheet and voluntarily consent to take part in the study.